

When I gently brought this up to her, Meme didn't apologize. I reminded her that the only time she ever directly gave me money was once when I called her crying. (A story we'll get to in Chapter 4 on unpaid internships.) As far as she can remember, she said, aside from that one time, I never *asked* her for money. She feels no remorse in not giving me what I didn't ask for. I said I normally felt too guilty to ask. I was just a kid; she was an adult. She shrugged: and said, "Tough shit." Conversation over.

If Meme was into luxury, her son, my dad, swung completely the other way. He became a flower child. Woodstock, long hair, bell-bottoms, VW vans, acid tabs. He realized the importance of money after Meme's second divorce, when he had to babysit his sister a lot more. The two kids always shared a room. Sometimes all three of them shared a studio.

My dad's first wife was a fellow hippie. They opened a handmade leather goods shop together in Gainesville, Florida, which they called MASANDU, in 1972. (Google Maps informs me that the original location is now, sadly, a Papa John's.) In 1973, my half-brother was born. My dad was gambling and drinking to excess, and his wife, who owned half of the store, wanted a divorce. Not wanting to "work for her," my dad said he cleared out the entire inventory and sold the store before she could have it, thereby winning the Petty Olympics of 1975.

In the early 1980s, he met my mom, an ambitious redhead studying law. They married in 1983. In 1988, I was born! (Hello, me! You have no idea what you're in for!)

Throughout the next decade, my dad ran a couple of businesses, but he was held back by his addictions—alcohol, gambling, and cocaine. "I had probably taken a cut in pay 'cause of my escapades," he said.

My dad was a fun, well-intentioned guy, but considering consequences and planning ahead were not really his thing. Social anxiety and insecurity led to his go-to: buying drinks for everyone in the place. Put it on your tab, and you become the most popular person in the bar.

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